

LEARNING

Nobody is bad at math

Something specific is missing, and it is almost always
further back than anyone is looking.

DEFINITION

Prerequisite gap

A skill from an earlier year that never got solid.

Everything built on top of it wobbles, and the wobble looks from the outside like a general inability.



What it looks like vs what it is

LOOKS LIKE

they freeze on every word problem.

IS

they cannot reliably turn a sentence into an equation.

**One of those is a personality.
The other is a Tuesday.**



Common gaps, and where they surface

Fractions	surfacing in algebra
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Negative signs	surfacing in factoring
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Place value	surfacing in decimals
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Ratios	surfacing in almost everything
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How to find the gap

1

Ask them to narrate a problem out loud.

2

Listen for where the narration stops.

3

Look earlier than that. The stall point is rarely the gap itself.



Diagnosis beats effort

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More hours on the wrong topic is not more learning, it is just more hours. Students who plateau are usually working hard at the thing they already know.



Find the gap, and the ability appears

That is what a good first session is for, and it is why
the first session matters most.

